Antler

Deer family antler, which is a fun material to turn, is available in a wide variety of sizes and shapes depending on the species

The antler pedicle or base is often turned to create a lidded box leaving the unique outer surfaces

Antler is a fun material to turn on your lathe. Depending on where you live, you may have access to naturally shed antler just by walking through the woods. The best time to find shed antlers in the wild is late winter to early spring. Grown on the members of the deer family, this bone material can range in size from quite small (roe deer) to incredibly large (elk and moose). For those who don't have access to antler from the hunting community or naturally shed, a variety of antler is available for purchase on Ebay and other mail order outlets. Antler is often marketed as dog chew material.

The make-up of antler is nearly identical regardless of the species or size. The outer shell is hard and solid with the inner portions being porous in the thicker sections of the antler. This porosity can be a problem for the turner depending on their planned project.

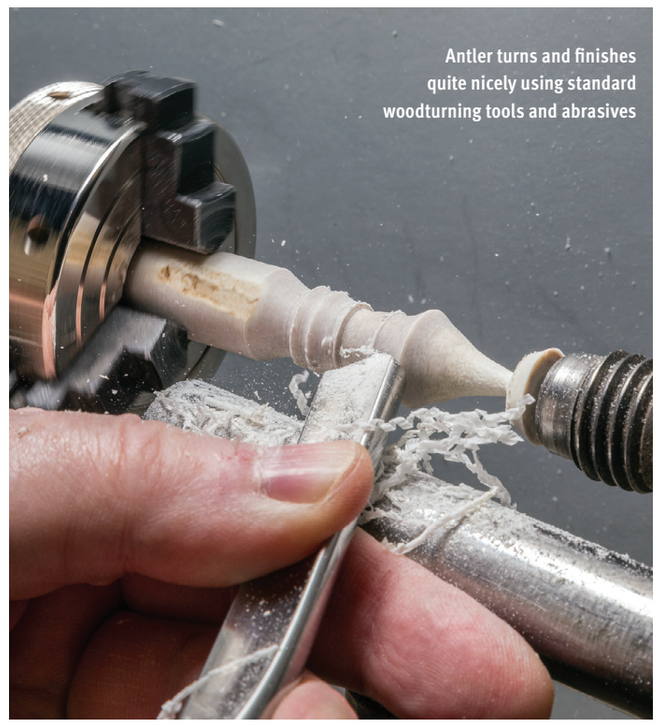
The two methods that I have had success with when the porous inner-antler material presents a problem are CA adhesive and stabilisation. To fill the pores, soak the area with thin cyanoacrylate adhesive, allowing it to wick in. If accelerator is needed, use it very sparingly to prevent the white foaming. Just mist a small amount of accelerator on the surface to allow the cross-linking process to kick off. As you continue to cut into the porous areas, you may need to repeat the CA treatment. If you have the capability to do stabilisation, the exposed ends of a cut antler will allow that stabilising chemicals to be drawn in by vacuum and then heat processed to rigidity. The hard outer shell material will vary widely in wall thickness based on the species and antler size. Antler material is usable from any portion from the pedicle (base) to the crown tine (the very tip of the antler). The diameter, shape, and curvature comes into play. Stunning lidded boxes can be made from the pedicles of larger antlers.

Don't turn away the hard outside irregularities. They add character. Much like you'd match the top and bottom of a box, the same can be done with the antler material. Pen makers are big users of antler material. Picking a straight area of the antler to cut and drill, the outer portion can be left intact providing a rustic look if desired.

Turning away the outer casing may reach into the porous inner and need to be stiffened for turning and finishing.

Antler has varying densities from the hard outer shell to the sometimes very porous inner portions

In addition to purchasing antler online, you can find sources for water buffalo horn



Antler turns and finishes quite nicely using standard woodturning tools and abrasives

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